

Reporting Abuse in SC

Abuse by a Parent or Guardian

Report to either county department of social services (DSS) or local law enforcement in the county the child resides.

→South Carolina Department of Social Services:

<https://dss.sc.gov/abuseneglect/report-abuse-and-neglect/>

→Abuse/Neglect number listed by county at:

<https://dss.sc.gov/contact/>

Abuse by a Non-Parent

Report to local law enforcement.

Abuse by Childcare Facility

In this instance, a parent or guardian should call the Out of Home Abuse and Neglect Intake Hotline at DSS:

Between 8:30am -5:00pm: 1-803-898-7669

After Hours: 1-800-645-9789

SC Department of Children's Advocacy (DCA)

Submit complaints regarding services being provided to a child by a state agency at:

<https://childadvocate.sc.gov/submit-complaint>

National Child Abuse Hotline

1-800-4-A-CHILD (1-800-422-4453)

This confidential service is available 24/7, using professional crisis counselors that are able to provide an array of services.



Abuse, Neglect and Exploitation:

What is it and how do you report it?



PALMETTO COORDINATED SYSTEM OF CARE

What is Abuse?

Physical

Occurs when a child suffers physical injuries that are not the result of an accident. Physical abuse does not always result in injuries or marks that are visible.

Sexual

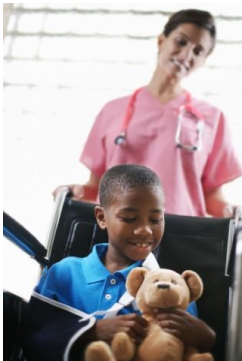
Occurs when an adult or stronger/older child takes advantage of a child in a sexual way, including:

- Touching a child's genitals (under or above clothing)
- Showing pornographic or inappropriate pictures to a child, or sending sexual text or emails to a child
- Asking a child for sexual contact or using sexually suggestive language with a child on the internet

Emotional

Occurs when a child is verbally or mentally abused. This may include:

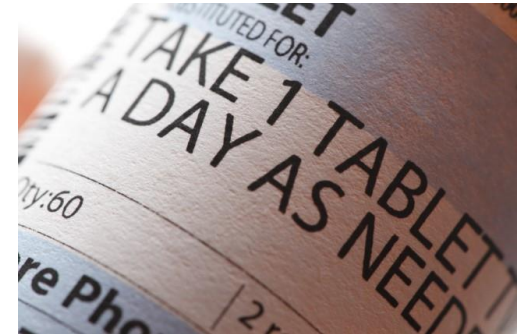
- Teasing or bullying
- Exposure of a child to domestic or family violence



What is Neglect?

Occurs when a child's basic needs are not met and their health and development is affected. Basic needs include:

- Food
- Safe and clean environment
- Timely medical care
- Clean clothing and clothing that protects from the weather
- Personal hygiene (cleanliness)



What is Exploitation?

The illegal or improper use of a child, or the resources of a child for personal gain, financial profit or sexual gratification.

Some examples include:

- Taking or using a child's property without authorization (child support, social security checks)
- Forcing a child to sell or distribute illegal drugs

Possible Signs of:

Abuse (General)

- Fear or mistrust of adults
- Frequent bedwetting or soiling of underpants
- Eating disorders or sudden weight changes
- Sleep problems or nightmares
- Unexplained injuries or explanations that are vague/unbelievable
- Drawing violent pictures or writing violent stories

Abuse (Sexual)

- Torn or stained undergarments
- Presence of a sexually transmitted disease
- Exhibiting sexual behaviors not usual for a child's stage of development

Neglect

- Malnutrition, begging, stealing or hoarding food
- Poor hygiene, matted hair, dirty skin and body odor
- Untreated medical problems



How to Protect Your Child:

Teach your child:

- Say “no” when someone asks to do something that makes them uncomfortable
- Always tell a parent or trusted adult when someone hurts or scares them or makes them feel bad

Talk to your child:

- Explain a good touch (hug, pat on the back) as opposed to a bad touch (touching private areas)
- Explain that no one is allowed to touch them in areas that would be covered by a bathing suit
 - ➔ Exceptions include a parent bathing a child, helping a child use the restroom or an examination by a doctor or nurse at a healthcare facility with a parents' permission
- Explain they can tell anyone “no” if touched in private areas
- Explain that if anyone touches them in private areas, they should tell a trusted adult immediately

